Abacus
A frame of rods and sliding beads used for counting before written numbers were common.

Abbey
A building where monks or nuns live, work and pray, often with a church at its center.

Abide
To put up with something, or to stay in a place for a long time.

Ablaze
On fire, or lit so brightly that it seems to burn.

Abode
The place where a person lives; a home.

Abrupt
Sudden and unexpected, often in a way that feels rough or curt.

Absorb
To take in a liquid, a sound or an idea so that it becomes part of oneself.

Abstract
Existing as an idea rather than as a thing that can be touched.

Abundant
Present in large amounts; more than enough.

Academy
A school for special training, or a society of scholars and artists.

Accent
A way of speaking that shows where a person comes from, or a mark placed over a letter.

Accord
Agreement between people; also to give or grant something.

Acorn
The nut of the oak tree, which sits in a small cup.

Acquire
To come to own or know something, by effort or by chance.

Acrobat
A performer who does difficult feats of balance and agility.

Adapt
To change so as to suit a new use or a new place.

Adhere
To stick firmly to a surface, or to keep to a rule or a belief.

Admire
To regard a person or a thing with respect and pleasure.

Adrift
Floating without anchor or steering; without a purpose.

Advent
The arrival of an important person, thing or event.

Aerial
Of the air, or high above the ground; also a wire for receiving radio signals.

Affair
A matter of concern or business; also a brief and private relationship.

Agile
Able to move quickly and lightly, in body or in mind.

Alcove
A small space set back into the wall of a room.

Alder
A tree of damp ground with rounded leaves and small cones.

Amber
Fossil resin, golden and clear, often worn as a jewel; also its yellow-brown color.

Anchor
A heavy object lowered on a chain to hold a ship in place.

Angle
The space between two lines that meet, measured in degrees; also a point of view.

Annual
Happening once every year.

Anvil
A heavy block of iron on which a smith shapes hot metal.

Apex
The highest point of something; the tip.

Apron
A garment worn over the front of the body to keep clothes clean.

Arbor
A shady place in a garden, formed by climbing plants on a frame.

Arch
A curved structure that spans an opening and carries the weight above it.

Arrow
A thin shaft with a point, shot from a bow; also a sign that shows a direction.

Ash
The gray powder left after something has burned; also a tree with pale wood.

Aspen
A kind of poplar whose leaves tremble in the slightest wind.

Atlas
A book of maps.

Attic
A space or room just under the roof of a house.

Aurora
Bands of light seen in the sky near the poles; also the dawn.

Autumn
The season between summer and winter, when leaves fall.

Avenue
A broad road, often lined with trees; also a way of approaching a problem.

Awning
A cover of canvas over a door or window to keep off sun and rain.

Axle
The rod on which a wheel turns, or that turns with it.

Azalea
A shrub with bright flowers that open in spring.

Azimuth
The angle of a direction measured clockwise from north, used in navigation.